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May 2026

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

It is my great pleasure to recommend Mengnan Xu for the Postdoctoral Fellowship at the Centre on Contemporary China and the World. I have served as Mengnan's academic advisor since she enrolled in the Master of Public Management program at Beijing Normal University in 2016 — a supervisory relationship now spanning nearly a decade that has taken her through her master's research, her doctoral dissertation, and two major collaborative research programs I have led. Among the many Master's and PhD students I have supervised over more than thirty years, Mengnan is genuinely distinctive. I recommend her without reservation.

Mengnan completed her Master's program with a thesis I regarded as publication-ready, demonstrating throughout a rare capacity for critical thinking and independent analytical reasoning that distinguished her from her peers. On the strength of that performance, I invited her to continue in the PhD program as my doctoral advisee. Her doctoral dissertation — a causal evaluation of China's Targeted Poverty Alleviation program using seven waves of CFPS panel data — passed blind external review and is scheduled for oral defense in May 2026. It represents a serious contribution to the empirical study of Chinese welfare governance.

The work I want to place at the centre of this letter is the original data infrastructure Mengnan has constructed under my direct supervision, and the research it has made possible. The Gates Foundation China tobacco control initiative I chaired — a \$5.5 million project involving the National Health Commission, Ministry of Finance, China Taxation Administration, the State Council Research and Development Center, non-profit organizations, and academic communities — relied on Mengnan for data platform construction and cross-institutional coordination. She is a researcher who identifies what needs to be built before being asked: during that project, she independently designed and constructed two databases — the China Tobacco Industry Watch and the China National Social Organization Database — that became central infrastructure for the research program. We co-authored papers from this work, including a publication in *BMJ Open* (Q1).

Building on that foundation, Mengnan has since constructed, under my supervision, two original databases that constitute the empirical core of our joint working papers. The first is a multi-actor coordination database documenting government agency, enterprise, and social organization participation in China's poverty alleviation governance from 2010 to 2023, constructed from policy documents, government reports, and organizational records at national scale. The second is a social organization database covering over 2,000 organizations with over two years of longitudinal data on funding flows and project activity. These datasets did not exist in the field before this work. Their construction required the ability to integrate heterogeneous sources at scale, sustained methodological judgment, and a conceptual grasp of how organizational participation structures

shape governance outcomes — not merely technical execution.

These databases are the empirical foundation for two collaborative working papers I am co-authoring with Mengnan. The first proposes the concept of a “development governance knowledge system” — a model of state-led multi-actor coordination that departs structurally from the NGO-centered frameworks dominant in international development research. The second develops a replicable computational pipeline for large-scale analysis of Chinese governance documents. Both papers are in active development, with data collection and processing complete; submission is planned during the postdoctoral fellowship period.

With my encouragement, Mengnan took a year to deepen her AI engineering capabilities at Apple’s Intelligence platform, where she worked on production-scale natural language processing systems. I supported this decision because the research agenda we have been building together demands more than statistical competence — it requires someone who can construct and validate large-scale computational pipelines with an engineer’s discipline. That experience, brought back to the governance document corpora we have been assembling, means the methods in our working papers are grounded in first-hand knowledge of how these systems perform under real-world conditions. For CCCW, this translates into a researcher who can advance AI-driven governance analysis not merely as an analytical technique, but as a rigorous and reproducible scholarly methodology.

This body of work speaks directly to CCCW’s research priorities. The organizational ecology of China’s poverty alleviation implementation — who participates, through which institutional channels, and with what coordination logic — is precisely the kind of sub-national governance analysis that complements the Centre’s research on Chinese political leadership and party-state capacity. Her native Mandarin fluency and command of academic English, combined with her experience coordinating across government, university, and foundation settings, make her well suited to CCCW’s intellectually demanding and internationally oriented research environment.

In working with Mengnan over these years, I have found her to be efficient, self-directed, and genuinely caring toward her colleagues. She served as a teaching assistant in my doctoral seminars, where she demonstrated a clear ability to explain complex methodological material, provide constructive feedback on student work, and support a productive learning environment. She is warm, confident, optimistic, and intellectually ambitious — qualities that made her an exceptional member of my research team and that I believe will make her a valued colleague at CCCW. I recommend her to your fellowship with full confidence.

Sincerely,

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